wickets in his third spell, having entered it with miserly figures of, say, 0–22.

We do different jobs, but share the same attitudes. We should never have become best mates, since we appear to be polar opposites in many ways, but mutual respect has allowed us to develop one of those close friendships that rarely flourish in something as intense and insecure as international sport.

There are not many people, in any walk of life, with whom you can speak honestly, to the point of baring your soul. Our relationship is underpinned by that sort of trust. We are also so comfortable in one another's presence that we can spend an evening together, ordering room service and doing our own thing, barely exchanging a word.

On the field, Jimmy used me as a sounding board. I helped him to control his emotions, but knew he had to reach a certain level of agitation to get the best out of himself. To go back to those psychological profiles, I was the assassin, trying to keep the warrior in check. I'd watch for the warning signs, of him walking back to his mark too quickly, for example, and steaming back in without really thinking about what he intended to do.

I think he, in turn, recognized and respected my single-mindedness and my resistance to pressure. He knew I wasn't imposing my authority as captain on him when I told him he was bowling half a yard too short, or too full. He understood I was thinking with him, rather than for him, when I suggested he should try to swing the ball rather than wobble it.

A captain's sensitivity to the mood of his bowlers is vital. On a day when we had the opportunity to bat long and deep he was full of the joys of spring. On a bowling day, he wouldn't say a word on the bus on the way to the ground. He was absorbed by the nature of the forthcoming challenge; he knew it would be hard, even though he makes bowling look easy. An unguarded comment at the wrong time and there would have been hell to pay.

Jimmy needed to be half-wired, and I had to be strong enough to ride out the response if I said or did something he didn't like. There have been times when I've had to tell him, 'You're gone,' and taken him out of the attack. He would flare up, go into a strop for a couple of overs, and then sulk for a bit. He would never want to stew in his own juices out at long on, though. I knew keeping him closer to the action at mid-off would accelerate the process of getting his head back in the game.